Ans. Farmers in the country have been facing financial hardship due to several reasons – consecutive droughts, indebtness and crop failures – farmers' suicide have always been in news in the recent time. Consequent upon the announcement by the Union Finance Minister in Budget Speech 2006-07, public-sector banks, regional rural banks and rural co-operative credit institutions were advised that with effect from Kharif 2006-07, government would provide interest rate subvention of **2** per cent per annum in respect of short-term production credit up to Rs. 3.0 lakh. This subvention was available to public sector banks, regional rural banks and rural co-operatives on the condition that they made short-term credit available at **7** per cent per annum. In case of RRBs and rural cooperatives, this was applicable only to short-term production credit disbursed out of their own funds and did not include such credit supported by NABARD refinance.

Pursuant to the *Union Budget 2010-11* announcement, it was decided to provide interest subvention of 1.5 per cent per annum for short-term agriculture loans up to Rs. 3.0 lakh disbursed by public-sector banks, cooperatives, and RRBs. The additional subvention for prompt repayment has been enhanced to **2** per cent per annum so that the effective interest rate charged to such farmers is 5 per cent per annum up to Rs. 3.0 lakh. In the *Budget 2011-12*, the government of India proposed to provide interest subvention of 1.5 per cent per annum for short term agriculture loans up to Rs. 3.0 lakh disbursed by public sector banks, co-operatives and RRBs. The additional subvention for prompt paying farmers is proposed to be enhanced to 3 per cent per annum so that the effective interest rate charged to these farmers is 4 per cent per annum upto Rs. 3.0 lakh. The programme has also been continued by the *Union Budget 2013-14*.

Q. 43 Write a note on the advantage to India in the world of 'Wellness Tourism'.

Ans. Several studies have estimated the global market for medical tourism ranging from US$ 100 billion to US$ 150 billion. The Asian medical tourism market is being bolstered by initiatives taken by the national governments, as also rising quality standards.